CINEMA

THE PRICE OF FREEDOM

Nikhil Advani's adaptation of *Freedom at Midnight* details our tumultuous transition to an independent nation

On a hot morning in April, filmmaker Nikhil Advani looks into a vintage wooden mirror as he gets his hair and beard trimmed in the middle of the road. The said road is part of an impressive set mounted for Advani's passion project, *Freedom at Midnight*, a SonyLIV series which drops on November 15. Based on Larry Collins and Dominique Lapierre's eponymous book, the show tracks key events in India's tumultuous battle for independence beginning with Direct Action Day in 1946 and culminating with Mahatma Gandhi's assassination. It's 7.30 in the morning, but Advani is wide awake as he gives a tour of the sets, suitably sooty to show the aftermath of the Partition riots. "With just one line [drawn on the map], 20 million people were uprooted and moved across borders. It is insane..." says Advani.

Freedom at Midnight may be rooted in a troubled past, but for Advani telling this magnum opus is deeply relevant. He says, "In my opinion, there cannot be another point of view on Gandhi. Yes, he had his eccentricities, but he mobilised 34 crore people to shut down on his word, at a time when there was no internet and social media." Spread across two seasons, the show covers a span of 13 months looking at the leaders and ordinary folk caught in the maelstrom. "It is important to understand that they [leaders] didn't know what was going to happen...that people would go mad. There was a lot of misunderstanding and miscommunication. Emotions were flying high." But all wasn't lost. "While there was a lot of trauma and violence, there was also hope. Hindus protected Muslims, Muslims protected Sikhs... Maulana Azad chose to stay back even after his house was attacked. That's what separates these men. I want to show that they were giants." Celebrating superheroes of a distant past is not unfamiliar territory for Advani whose banner, Emmay Entertainment, produced the acclaimed SonyLIV series, *Rocket Boys*, following the lives of scientists Vikram Sarabhai and Homi Bhabha. "I don't want to be simplistic but it also makes my life easier because there's a real-life event to recreate," says Advani about his penchant for history.

Still, he admits, *Freedom...* was not an easy story to tell. Four years in development, Advani and his team spent around 120 days in 2024 shooting, followed by several months in post-production with a fair bit of visual effects. A narrative device includes shifting between real footage and Advani's recreation. The show is also in some ways Advani's tribute to his own Sindhi ancestors, including his grandmother and father, who was six months old when his family left Hyderabad in Sindh, Pakistan, to move to a one-bedroom flat in Bombay, India. "For the longest time, my grandmother would talk about how we were the richest family in Clifton, Karachi, and how her father was the first person to have a Ford car," says Advani. The scars of Partition remained, he says, but with time his grandma learned to put aside her distrust of Muslims and would even welcome a Muslim son-in-law into the family. "Finally, she agreed. I hope at some point we all heal," says Advani. ■

–Suhani Singh





Passion project Nikhil Advani; a scene from *Freedom at Midnight*

MILIND SHELTE